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At Croft, a race for funds comes up short

School moved tuition deadline up while finances, expansion effort came undone

By John Hilliard
GLOBE STAFF

The leader of the troubled Croft School needed money. In late December, Scott Given allegedly forged a \$500,000 letter of credit to back a lease on a building in the South End for an expansion of his private, for-profit elementary school, according to the institution's directors. Three days later, Given notified

families he was moving up the deadline for tuition. On the day after Christmas, he told parents they would need to pay a 10 percent deposit in mid-February — five weeks earlier than in past years, according to copies of the emails obtained by the Globe. With tuition costing over \$30,000, the early deadline meant that more than 350 families in Mas-

sachusetts and Rhode Island would be forking over a total of as much as \$1 million to Croft at a critical time. Given, who founded Croft in 2017, did not respond to requests for comment sent to his lawyers. At the time of the new tuition deadline, Given had just signed a 10-year lease to take over the former Foodie's grocery store on Washington Street beginning in July, at a rent of approximately \$104,000 a month. When neighbors of the building objected to the move, Given tried to

back out of the lease. That's when everything unraveled, according to emails from the board and a lawsuit in Suffolk Superior Court. On March 6, the owner of the South End building went to Leader Bank to cash in the \$500,000 letter of credit. The bank immediately spotted the forgery and called Boston police, which sent several officers to the scene, court records show. A Boston police spokesperson confirmed Friday the department **CROFT SCHOOL, Page A7**

Another Trump suit for Harvard

White House again raises allegations of antisemitism

By Brooke Hauser and Hilary Burns
GLOBE STAFF

One year after the Trump administration launched its offensive against Harvard University in the name of combating antisemitism, the Justice Department on Friday sued the school yet again, saying faculty and leadership had “turned a blind eye to antisemitism and discrimination against Jews and Israelis.” This is the second lawsuit by the Justice Department against Harvard in little more than one month, the prior one over access to enrollment data to determine if the school was complying with race-blind admissions in the wake of the Supreme Court's repeal of affirmative action. The sustained pressure campaign against the Ivy League school comes despite a federal judge's declaration in September the administration used allegations of antisemitism as a “smoke-screen for a targeted, ideologically-motivated assault on this country's premier universities.” In that case, Harvard had sued over the cancellation of nearly \$3 billion in federal research funds to the university, and the administration is now appealing the judge's ruling. The two latest lawsuits again ratchet up the battle between the White House and the Ivy League university at a time when anticipation of a possible negotiated settlement had abated, and **HARVARD, Page A10**

Musicians and audience greet Nelsons with strong support

By Malcolm Gay and A.Z. Madonna
GLOBE STAFF

Andris Nelsons received a hero's welcome at Symphony Hall Thursday night, his first performance with the Boston Symphony Orchestra since its board of trustees rocked the staid world of classical music by parting ways with the conductor because he wasn't “aligned on future vision.” Dressed in black, Nelsons basked in applause and clasped his hands in a show of gratitude as the substantial crowd rose to its feet to cheer him on. The musicians, who adore their maestro, had moments earlier telegraphed their support from the stage: Entering en masse, each had adorned their outfit with a single red carnation, a show of solidarity and a nod to the dominant color of the flag of Latvia, Nelsons' home country. It was an emotional homecoming for the conductor, who said he neither anticipated the decision nor wanted to leave when his contract expires at the end of the 2027 Tanglewood season. Nevertheless, Nelsons quickly got down to business, leading the orchestra and pianist Yunchan Lim through Robert Schumann's moody “Pi- **NELSONS, Page A7**



BARRY CHIN/GLOBE STAFF

A lion at the Capron Park Zoo in Attleboro. To save money, the city is proposing transforming the zoo into a nature reserve and wildlife rehabilitation center, which would mean finding new homes for some of the animals.

Pressed for cuts, officials count the cost of zoos, libraries, rinks

Rising prices, taxation rules, and stagnant aid mean nothing is off limits

By Claire Thornton and Nick Stoico
GLOBE STAFF
and Hannah Goeke
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

The finances of Massachusetts cities and towns have gotten so bad that one community can no longer afford to keep Lacey the Amur leopard and other animals of the Capron Park Zoo in Attleboro. Faced with rising costs and limited revenue, Attleboro is proposing to transform Capron into a nature reserve and wildlife rehabilitation center, a move that could require finding new homes for the endangered leopard, one of the rarest big cats in the world,

and dozens of other animals, Mayor Cathleen DeSimone said Thursday. As abrupt as the closure may seem, DeSimone said the pressure has been building for years. “There's no ideal time to start” moving animals, DeSimone said. “But this issue has been kicked down the road for a while.” The fate of Capron is the latest example of the fallout from a deepening fiscal crisis that has forced cities and towns to consider similar cuts to cherished public institutions, including libraries to skating rinks. “It's happening very broadly,” said Adam Chapdelaine, executive director of the Massa-

chusetts Municipal Association. “There's really no outlier communities that are immune to this.” Officials and policy experts said the problems stem from a familiar formula that is only making matters worse over time: costs that are rising faster than revenues, a state law in Proposition 2½ that limits their ability to raise taxes, and state aid that has not kept pace with inflation and local needs. In a report released in December, the municipal association described the situation as a “perfect storm” of fiscal pressure, citing sharp rises in the cost of health insurance, **ZOO, Page A10**

Not alcoholic, also not cheap

Fancy booze-free cocktails filling a hole in restaurant budgets

By Bryan Hecht
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

Gone are the days when teetotaling diners had to choose between fountain sodas and dusty old bottles of O'Doul's. High-priced, high-brow non-alcoholic drinks are proliferating at bars and restaurants across Boston. There's the \$17 “Theta Range” featuring earthy red vegetables and amber resin extract at Back Bay's Hecate speakeasy. The “Lucano Libre” at Alcove near TD Garden costs \$13 and boasts cane-sugar soda mixed with a pricey zero-proof Italian aperitif. In Kendall Square, Shy Bird's Tilden Lacewing offers a taste of cucumber, basil, lychee, and juniper berry for \$12 — not much cheaper than the establishment's boozier cocktails. With more customers buying less alcohol while dining out — a trend sparked by younger people who tend to drink less — restaurants are turning to handcrafted “mocktails” to recover some of those essential profits. “You worried because alcohol sales are so important, but now we're pricing these mocktails and beers just about similar to your average cocktail or beer ... and no one bats an eye,” **NO ALCOHOL, Page A7**



MATTHEW J. LEE/GLOBE STAFF

A Spice Tamarind Margarita is among the alcohol-free mocktails at Alcove Boston.



A grayed above

Saturday: Clouds and sun. High: 50-55. Low: 33-38.
Sunday: Cloudy, showers. High: 47-52. Low: 33-38.
High tide: 1:15 a.m. 1:44 p.m.
Sunrise: 6:46 Sunset: 6:57
Comics and Weather, **D4-5.**

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\$4.00



Chuck Norris, who channeled his skills in martial arts into a durable acting career, died. The fan favorite was 86. **C9.**
The US has ramped up assaults against Iranian drones and naval vessels, US officials said, in an effort to reopen the Strait of Hormuz. **A4.**
A judge dismissed a lawsuit brought against Boston Public Schools by a group representing parents whose children were denied admission to the city's exam schools. **B1.**